that they were made to feel ‘conspicuous and outclassed’. After his mother remarried, he says that the boys of the school said ‘all kinds of things’ about both of them.

Ratan reminisces ruefully: ‘I hardly had any friends in Cathedral because my mother and father were separated and my brother and I would always tag along with my father, so his friends became our friends. I hardly ever had any friends [of my own].’ Of the three he says he had, Zubin Mehta, the famous orchestral conductor, and his brother, would occasionally come to Tata House. The other friend, Behram Dubash, is now a veteran in the shipping industry and involved in his family construction business. Ratan continues to meet him over an occasional meal.

After their parents’ separation, Ratan and Jimmy became so insecure that they would try and tag along with their father wherever possible. They would also accompany him to the Sunday lunch that Naval hosted for his friends in a small house in Juhu. They were the only children there amongst the adults. Ratan had his first taste of liquor at one such party. Occasionally, someone would pour a few drops into a small glass and offer it to him, saying, ‘Come on, join in the fun.’ But liquor did not delight him. He recalls that he ‘never enjoyed it’ and, in fact, he and his brother ‘hated it’.

Although after his parents’ divorce, Ratan became closer to Lady Tata, he was also deeply influenced by his father. Naval was a deeply compassionate man. He was concerned about the plight of the poor. This sense of compassion also took root in Ratan. Naval was jovial and mild-mannered and taught his children to value what they had and abjure an ostentatious lifestyle. Many of these characteristics moulded Ratan’s personality. When he was fifty-two, in a letter to his father, Ratan gratefully acknowledged Naval’s role in inculcating compassion and other values in him.

‘It is impossible for me to accept credit without truthfully and unabashedly telling you that whatever I have achieved has drawn heavily on the upbringing and value systems you gave me in my early life,’ he wrote. ‘I am particularly grateful to you for teaching me humility and kindness to the poor. In some ways, I now appreciate being taught not to be “pushing and aggressive—or demanding for oneself”. While you always gave us enough, you were careful to see we didn’t get too much of anything—and so I value what I have and don’t crave for too much more.’

These are not the only qualities Ratan learned from his father. Known for his crisp delivery, he is one of the few industrialists who prefers to speak